

University of Heidelberg
Faculty of Physics and Astronomy
Beginners Physics Lab 1

Versuch 15 – Inclined Plane

Author:	Jonathan Gießen
Group:	Group 8
Supervisor:	Matha Reece
Experiment Date:	15. September 2026

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AI-Disclaimer

AI tools were used to assist in translating, as well as in the generation of text in section 1

1 Introduction

The experiment investigates the fundamental mechanics of rigid bodies moving down an inclined plane. By observing different rolling bodies specifically a solid cylinder and a hollow cylinder the experiment explores how mass distribution affects rotational and translational motion. The main objectives are to quantitatively determine the acceleration of these bodies as they roll down the ramp and to verify the law of conservation of mechanical energy by comparing the initial potential energy with the final translational and rotational kinetic energy.

2 Basic Principles and Theorie

The motion of a round body rolling down an inclined plane without slipping is governed by both linear and rotational dynamics. Two primary physical frameworks are utilized to analyze this motion: Newton's laws of motion and the principle of energy conservation.

2.1 Dynamics and Acceleration

When a body rolls down an inclined plane with an angle φ , it experiences a downhill force component from gravity ($F_H = mg \sin \varphi$) and an opposing static friction force (F_R). This friction force exerts a torque (moment of force) M relative to the center of mass, causing the body to rotate. The relationship between torque, the moment of inertia I , and angular acceleration $\frac{d\omega}{dt}$ is given by:

$$M = F_R \cdot r = I \frac{d\omega}{dt} \quad (2.1)$$

Using the rolling without slipping condition, the velocity of the center of gravity is $v_s = r\omega$. Differentiating this yields the relationship between linear acceleration a_s and angular acceleration, allowing us to express the friction force as:

$$F_R = \frac{I}{r^2} \cdot a_s \quad (2.2)$$

Applying Newton's second law for linear motion along the plane ($ma_s = mg \sin \varphi - F_R$) and substituting the friction force, the linear acceleration of the rolling body is derived as:

$$a_s = \frac{mg \sin \varphi}{m + \frac{I}{r^2}} \quad (2.3)$$

This formula demonstrates that the acceleration depends on the body's moment of inertia, explaining why a hollow cylinder and a solid cylinder roll at different rates despite having the same radius.[1]

2.2 Conservation of Energy

The motion can also be analyzed through the conservation of mechanical energy. Assuming no energy is lost to non-conservative forces (like air resistance or kinetic friction, since the static friction does no work), the initial potential energy is fully converted into kinetic

energy. The total energy W_{ges} is the sum of translational kinetic energy, rotational kinetic energy, and potential energy:

$$W_{ges} = \frac{1}{2}mv^2 + \frac{1}{2}I\omega^2 + mgh \quad (2.4)$$

As the body descends a vertical height h , the decrease in potential energy (mgh) equals the increase in total kinetic energy ($\frac{1}{2}mv^2 + \frac{1}{2}I\omega^2$).

3 Measuring Protocol

3.1 Setup and Tasks

Protokoll: Experiment 15: Inclined Plane

Jonathan Gießen, Theo Senner

15.9.2026

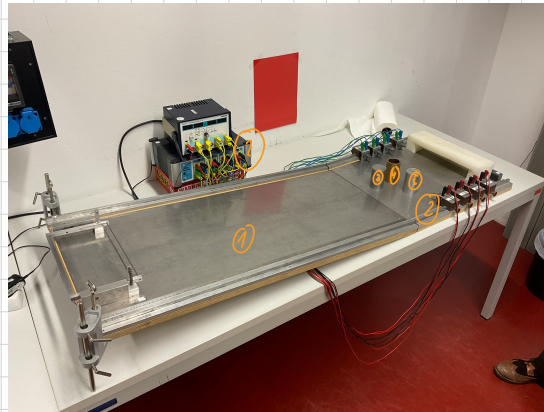


Bild 3.1 Setup

Setup :

- Height-adjustable runway (1)
- solid cylinder: alu, $\rho = 2,70 \frac{\text{g}}{\text{cm}^3}$ (3)
- hollow cylinder: brass, $\rho = 8,44 \frac{\text{g}}{\text{cm}^3}$ (4)
- composite cylinder: sheath of aluminum, core of brass (5)
- colliper
- Scale
- Spirit level

A1: Measurement

Tbl 3.1: Measurement of rolling bodies

cylinder	d _{inner} [mm]	d _{outer} [mm]	mass [g]
solid	0	5,00 ± 0,05	443,0 ± 1,0
hollow	4,65 ± 0,05	5,00 ± 0,05	443,0 ± 1,0
(composite)	0,76 ± 0,05	5,00 ± 0,05	443,0 ± 1,0

length of track [cm]: 100,0 ± 0,5 cm

With the error estimation based on the error of the ruler and the uncertainty of the measurement method (the plane the ruler is set on is not perfectly flat and there is a tiny gap between the measured length and the actual plane (curved))

$$\Delta \sigma = \frac{\sigma}{\sqrt{n}} \quad \Delta C = 0,05 \text{ cm}$$

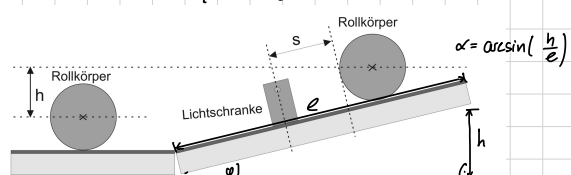
We adjust for the error of the colliper not being upright by doing multiple measurements.

$$\text{Total error: } \Delta = \sqrt{\Delta \sigma^2 + \Delta C^2}$$

Height of track [cm]:

- 1: 11,10
2: 12,80
3: 11,50
4: 12,80
5: 12,70
- $\bar{h} = (12,2 \pm 0,4) \text{ cm}$

with $\Delta \sigma = 0,37$



The time error for all time measurements is $\Delta t = \pm 0,001s$

A2: movement type? consistent acceleration

$$L_i = L_{\text{end}} - L_{\text{start}}, \Delta v_{\text{elec}} = 0,05 \text{ cm}$$

Tbl 3.2 Full cylinder

barrier [cm]	ΔL_{tot}	time [s]
$L_1 = 25,00 \pm 0,07$		$t_1 = 0,821$
$L_2 = 36,00 \pm 0,07$		$t_2 = 1,084$
$L_3 = 49,00 \pm 0,07$		$t_3 = 1,272$
$L_4 = 64,00 \pm 0,07$		$t_4 = 1,451$

Hollow cylinder

barrier [cm]	ΔL_{tot}	time [s]
$L_1 = 25,00 \pm 0,07$		$t_1 = 1,011$
$L_2 = 36,00 \pm 0,07$		$t_2 = 1,204$
$L_3 = 49,00 \pm 0,07$		$t_3 = 1,403$
$L_4 = 64,00 \pm 0,07$		$t_4 = 1,604$

The uncertainty of the light source not being perfectly centered is neglected in the face of the much bigger uncertainty of the wlen. Nevertheless it is worth for a mention.

We aligned both sides (sender and receiver) with the wlen so no alignment error aside from Δv is expected.

We add the two separate Δv :

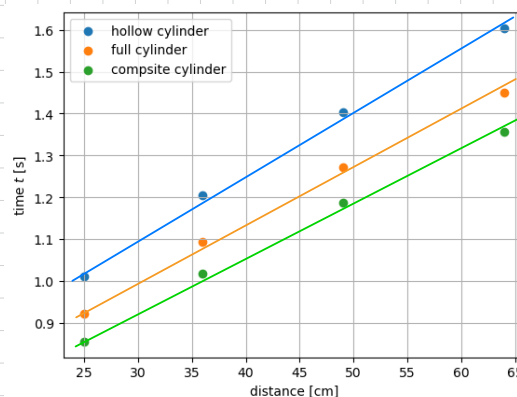
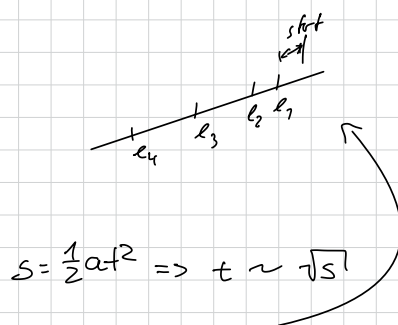
$$\Delta L_{\text{tot}} = \sqrt{\Delta v_1^2 + \Delta v_2^2} = \sqrt{2} \cdot 0,05 =$$

Δv_1 : sender side, Δv_2 : receiver side

Composed cylinder

barrier [cm]	ΔL_{tot}	time [s]
$L_1 = 25,00 \pm 0,07$		$t_1 = 0,855$
$L_2 = 36,00 \pm 0,07$		$t_2 = 1,018$
$L_3 = 49,00 \pm 0,07$		$t_3 = 1,186$
$L_4 = 64,00 \pm 0,07$		$t_4 = 1,356$

Plots:



Tabl. 3.3 Measurement of acceleration											
A3 [cm] dist $\Delta t_{tot} = 0.07$	time hollow $\Delta t =$ [ms]					t full [ms]					
$l_1 = 25$	1,019	1,027	1,014	1,022	1,009	0,922	0,914	0,900	0,901	0,913	
$l_2 = 36$	1,212	1,223	1,209	1,215	1,201	1,096	1,089	1,075	1,074	1,087	
$l_3 = 49$	1,410	1,426	1,410	1,415	1,400	1,278	1,268	1,255	1,254	1,266	
$l_4 = 64$	1,610	1,629	1,613	1,614	1,600	1,458	1,466	1,435	1,435	1,446	

Table 3.4
Mean + standard error:

	Hollow [s]	Full [s]
L_1 :	$1,018 \pm 0,004$	$0,906 \pm 0,006$
L_2 :	$1,212 \pm 0,004$	$1,080 \pm 0,005$
L_3 :	$1,412 \pm 0,004$	$1,260 \pm 0,006$
L_4 :	$1,613 \pm 0,005$	$1,440 \pm 0,006$

14:

```

: # messung, t1, t2

# hollow
m1h = np.array([1.922, 2.192])
m2h = np.array([1.951, 2.222])
m3h = np.array([1.936, 2.206])
m4h = np.array([1.922, 2.192])
m5h = np.array([1.938, 2.207])

# full
m1f = np.array([1.724, 1.967])
m2f = np.array([1.736, 1.980])
m3f = np.array([1.718, 1.961])
m4f = np.array([1.737, 1.981])
m5f = np.array([1.749, 1.992])

```

Tbl. 3.5 Measurement of translational velocity Hollow:

[cm]	Distance	Δt_{tot}	[s] ΔT_1	[s] ΔT_2	[s] ΔT_3	[s] ΔT_4	[s] ΔT_5
$\Delta L =$	$25,00 \pm 0,07$		0,270	0,271	0,270	0,270	0,269

$$\overline{T_H} = (0,2700 \pm 0,0010) \text{ s with } \Delta \overline{T_H} = \sqrt{\left(\frac{\sigma_{T_H}}{\sqrt{5}}\right)^2 + \Delta t^2} \Rightarrow \overline{v_H} = \frac{\Delta L}{\overline{T_H}}$$

Tbl. 3.6 Measurement of translational velocity Full:

[cm]	Distance	Δt_{tot}	[s] ΔT_1	[s] ΔT_2	[s] ΔT_3	[s] ΔT_4	[s] ΔT_5
$\Delta L =$	$25,00 \pm 0,07$		0,243	0,244	0,243	0,244	0,243

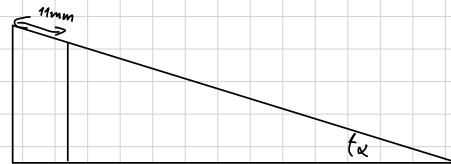
$$\overline{T_F} = (0,2430 \pm 0,0010) \text{ s with } \Delta \overline{T_F} = \sqrt{\left(\frac{\sigma_{T_F}}{\sqrt{5}}\right)^2 + \Delta t^2} \Rightarrow \overline{v_F} = \frac{\Delta L}{\overline{T_F}}$$

Error propagation!



img 3.2 Distance

Accepted
(b/a/26)



$$h = \sin(\alpha) \cdot (L - 11\text{mm})$$

V35

September 16, 2026

height of track

```
[5]: import numpy as np
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt

[2]: h = np.array([11.1, 12.8, 11.5, 12.8, 12.7])
err_h = 0.05

print(np.mean(h))
error_mean = np.std(h, ddof=1)/np.sqrt(len(h))
print(error_mean)
print(np.sqrt(error_mean**2 + err_h**2))

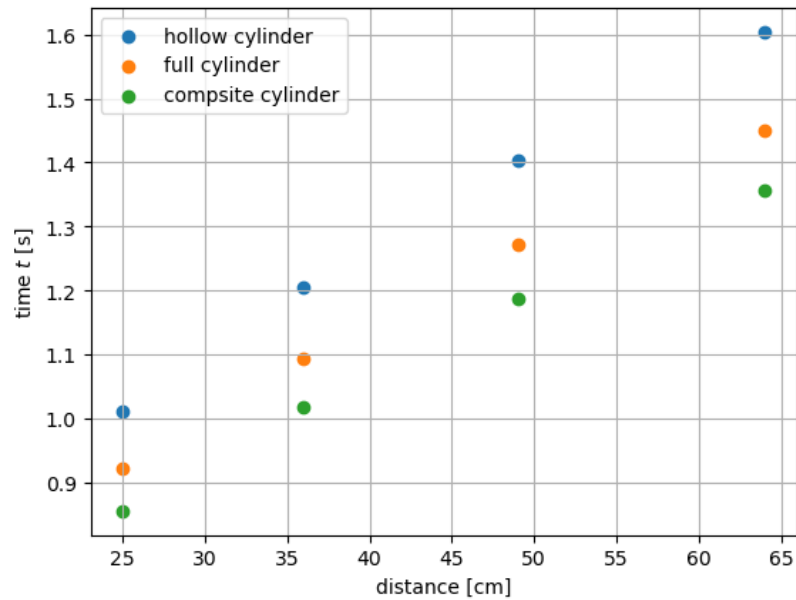
12.180000000000001
0.3652396473549936
0.3686461718233353

[ ]: t_hollow = np.array([1.011, 1.204, 1.403, 1.604])
t_full = np.array([0.921, 1.094, 1.272, 1.451])
t_compose = np.array([0.855, 1.018, 1.186, 1.356])

x = np.array([25, 36, 49, 64])

plt.scatter(x, t_hollow, label="hollow cylinder")
plt.scatter(x, t_full, label="full cylinder")
plt.scatter(x, t_compose, label="composite cylinder")
plt.xlabel("distance [cm]")
plt.ylabel("time $t$ [s]")
plt.grid(True)
plt.legend()

[ ]: <matplotlib.legend.Legend at 0x11bb9cb90>
```



Quantitative A3:

```
[13]: x = np.array([25, 36, 49, 64])

t_hollow = np.array([
    [1.019, 1.212, 1.410, 1.610],
    [1.027, 1.223, 1.426, 1.629],
    [1.014, 1.209, 1.410, 1.613],
    [1.022, 1.215, 1.415, 1.614],
    [1.009, 1.201, 1.400, 1.600]
])
t_full = np.array([
    [0.922, 1.096, 1.278, 1.459],
    [0.893, 1.068, 1.245, 1.425],
    [0.900, 1.075, 1.255, 1.435],
    [0.901, 1.074, 1.254, 1.435],
    [0.913, 1.087, 1.266, 1.446]
])

mean_hollow = np.mean(t_hollow, axis=0)
```

```

std_hollow = np.std(t_hollow, axis=0, ddof=1)/np.sqrt(t_hollow.shape[0]) #
↳Standard error of the mean
mean_full = np.mean(t_full, axis=0)
std_full = np.std(t_full, axis=0, ddof=1)/np.sqrt(t_full.shape[0]) # Standard
↳error of the mean

print("Hollow cylinder:")
for distance, mean, std in zip(x, mean_hollow, std_hollow):
    print(f"{distance} cm: mean = {mean:.4f} s, std = {std:.4f} s")

print("\nFull cylinder:")
for distance, mean, std in zip(x, mean_full, std_full):
    print(f"{distance} cm: mean = {mean:.4f} s, std = {std:.4f} s")

```

Hollow cylinder:

```

25 cm: mean = 1.0182 s, std = 0.0031 s
36 cm: mean = 1.2120 s, std = 0.0036 s
49 cm: mean = 1.4122 s, std = 0.0042 s
64 cm: mean = 1.6132 s, std = 0.0047 s

```

Full cylinder:

```

25 cm: mean = 0.9058 s, std = 0.0052 s
36 cm: mean = 1.0800 s, std = 0.0050 s
49 cm: mean = 1.2596 s, std = 0.0057 s
64 cm: mean = 1.4400 s, std = 0.0058 s

```

a4

```

[20]: # messung, t1, t2

# hollow
m1h = np.array([1.922, 2.192])
m2h = np.array([1.951, 2.222])
m3h = np.array([1.936, 2.206])
m4h = np.array([1.922, 2.192])
m5h = np.array([1.938, 2.207])

# full
m1f = np.array([1.724, 1.967])
m2f = np.array([1.736, 1.980])
m3f = np.array([1.718, 1.961])
m4f = np.array([1.737, 1.981])
m5f = np.array([1.749, 1.992])

m_diff_h = np.array([])
for i in [m1h, m2h, m3h, m4h, m5h]:
    m_diff_h = np.append(m_diff_h, i[1] - i[0])

```

```

m_diff_f = np.array([])
for i in [m1f, m2f, m3f, m4f, m5f]:
    m_diff_f = np.append(m_diff_f, i[1] - i[0])

err_t = 0.001
print("Hollow cylinder time differences:")
print(m_diff_h)
print("Mean time difference for hollow cylinder:", np.mean(m_diff_h))
print("Standard error for hollow cylinder:", np.std(m_diff_h, ddof=1)/
      len(m_diff_h))
print('Full error for hollow cylinder:', np.sqrt((np.std(m_diff_h, ddof=1)/
      len(m_diff_h))**2 + err_t**2))

print("\nFull cylinder time differences:")

print(m_diff_f)
print("Mean time difference for full cylinder:", np.mean(m_diff_f))
print("Standard error for full cylinder:", np.std(m_diff_f, ddof=1)/
      len(m_diff_f))
print('Full error for full cylinder:', np.sqrt((np.std(m_diff_f, ddof=1)/
      len(m_diff_f))**2 + err_t**2))

```

```

Hollow cylinder time differences:
[0.27  0.271 0.27  0.27  0.269]
Mean time difference for hollow cylinder: 0.27000000000000001
Standard error for hollow cylinder: 0.00014142135623730964
Full error for hollow cylinder: 0.0010099504938362077

Full cylinder time differences:
[0.243 0.244 0.243 0.244 0.243]
Mean time difference for full cylinder: 0.2434
Standard error for full cylinder: 0.00010954451150102927
Full error for full cylinder: 0.001005982107196743

```

3.2 Execution of the Experiment

The Experimental procedure involves the following main steps:

1. **Setup and Geometry Measurement:** Familiarizing with the light barrier control unit and stopwatch system. Measuring the diameters of the test bodies (solid and hollow cylinders) using a caliper. Using a spirit level to ensure the inclined plane has an even inclination across its entire width, adjusting the supports if necessary (No adjustment was needed in this case).
2. **Qualitative Analysis of Motion:** Verifying uniformly accelerated motion by placing the light barriers at appropriate intervals ($t \propto \sqrt{s}$). Observing and explain qualitatively why bodies with different mass distributions require different amounts of time to reach the bottom.
3. **Quantitative Acceleration Measurement:** Place the light barriers along the incline and measure their exact distances s from the starting mechanism. Release the solid and hollow cylinders and record the time it takes for them to pass the barriers. Repeat this measurement 5 times for each rolling body.
4. **Energy Conservation Study:** To evaluate the conservation of energy, two light barriers are positioned on the horizontal section at the end of the ramp. The final translational velocity of the bodies are measured. The calculated total kinetic energy will then be compared to the initial potential energy, which is derived from the height difference of the plane.

4 Evaluation

4.1 Exercise 1: Comparison of Acceleration (theoretical vs. Experimental)

The acceleration of the rolling bodies can be calculated using the derived formula:

$$a_s = \frac{g \sin \varphi}{1 + \frac{I}{mr^2}} \quad (4.1)$$

The Moment of inertia I for a solid cylinder is $I = \frac{1}{2}mr^2$, and for a hollow cylinder, it is $I = m(r_{out}^2 - r_{in}^2)$

With the measured parameters of the cylinders, the theoretical accelerations can be calculated. The parameters are summarized in Table 4.1.

Table 4.1: Parameters of the cylinders used in the experiment.

Parameter	Solid Cylinder	Hollow Cylinder
Mass [kg]	443.0 ± 1.0	443.0 ± 1.0
Inner Radius [m]	0	$(46.50 \pm 0.05) \times 10^{-3}$
Outer Radius [m]	$(50.00 \pm 0.05) \times 10^{-3}$	$(50.00 \pm 0.05) \times 10^{-3}$
Moment of Inertia [$\text{kg} \times \text{m}^2$]	1.384 ± 0.004	$(2.582 \pm 0.007) \times 10^{-4}$

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References

- [1] Dr. J.Wagner, *Physikalisches Anfängerpraktikum*, Stand 11/2024
- [2] W. Ilberg, M. Krötzsch, *Physikalisches Praktikum für Anfänger*, BSB B. G. Teubner Verlagsgesellschaft, Leipzig (1985).